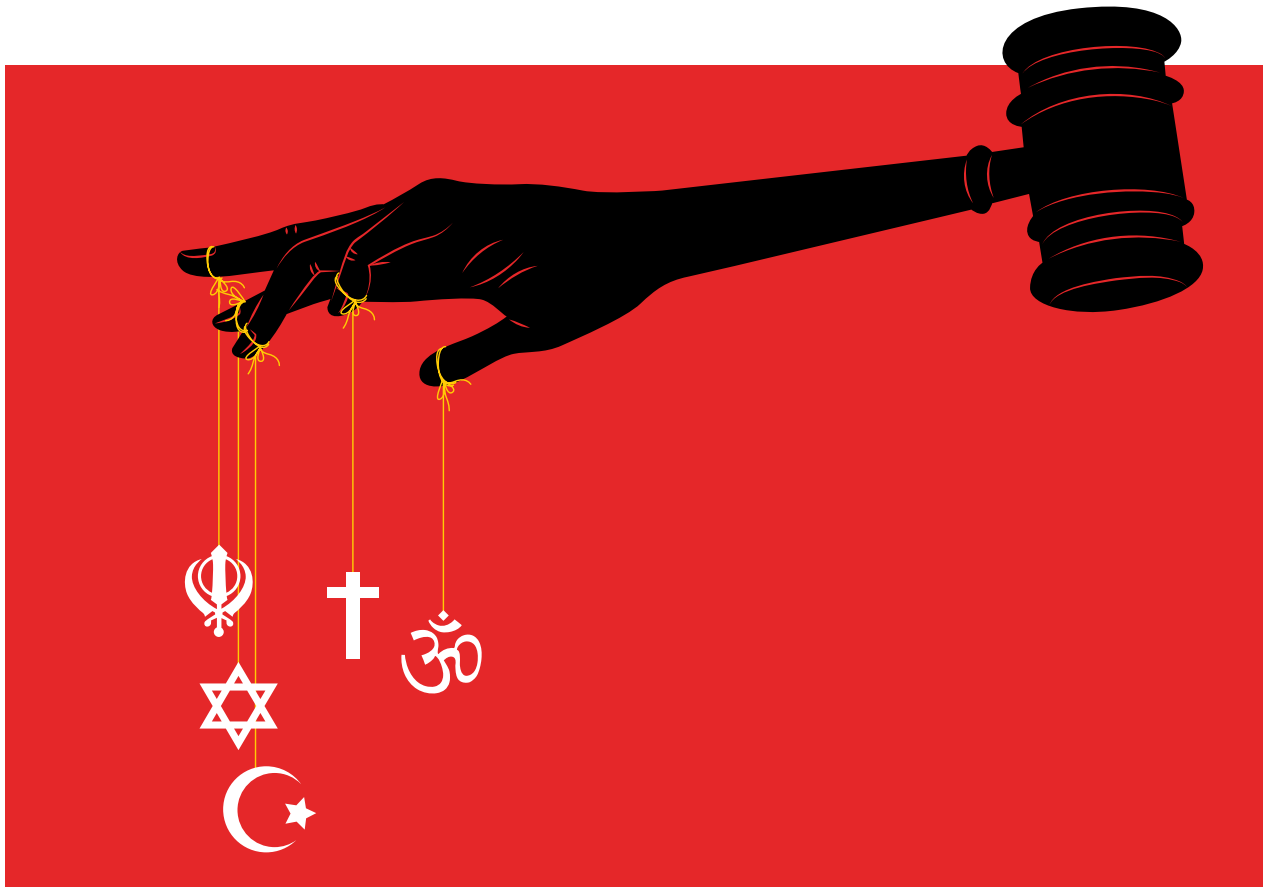
STATE SCAN

TELANGANA: A RIVER REBORN AS A QUESTION *PG 16*

PUNJAB: BAD NEWS FOR AAP *PG 18*



▶ MAHARASHTRA

CONVERSION, A CRIMINAL OFFENCE

The Fadnavis regime enacts one of India's toughest anti-conversion bills

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IN A MAJORITARIAN TURN THAT follows a long template, Maharashtra has become India's 13th state to enact an anti-conversion law. On March 16, the Devendra Fadnavis government approved a bill that criminalises change of faith in a wide variety of contexts. Its terms echo those set by its precursors: conversions would be deemed illegal if induced by allurements, misrepresentation, force, undue influence, coercion and the like. But critics say the law raises fears of a greater range of extra-legal misuse as well as a deeper ingress by the law into fundamental rights—of choice, privacy and equality.

The Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Act, 2026, widens the meaning of 'allurement'. It tags the usual culprits: material offers or temptation in the form of gifts, money, employment, free education, better lifestyle or promise to marry get tagged. To that, it adds non-material means: divine healing, glorifying one religion over another et al. Under "unlawful conversions", it lists "brainwashing through medium of education", a phrase red-flagged by many critics. Not only can a deemed victim's parents, siblings or loosely defined

Illustration by RAJ VERMA